Judgment for all pious men'—stands out because the Greek message does not include it. Overall, however, the Aramaic vocabulary seems able to get Ashoka's message without the possible interpretive difficulties of the Greek. The Persian cultural grounding of Aramaic seems more conducive to a translation of concepts from the heartland of Buddhism. The overt preoccupation of this edict with giving up the killing of animals, incidentally, continues to figure prominently in Ashoka's later Afghanistan epigraphs. The Aramaic Pul-i-Darunta stone inscription noted that no living being was to be 'fattened' with other living beings, while two other edicts, also in Aramaic, from Laghman speak about the king having dispersed and expelled from 'the prosperous (population) the lovers of . . . hunting of creatures and fishes.'[31]

But coming back to our Kandahar message: who exactly composed it and what decisions on its content were taken by the provincial administration rather than the emperor? Did an exemplar emanating from the king determine the matter or were the translators left largely free? These questions connect with how political authority was constituted in the separable parts of the Mauryan empire, the dominant issue studied by historians thus far being the extent or lack of an authoritative centralized administration. Evidence of varying kinds of authority exercised across different regions led Romila Thapar to describe the Mauryan administration 'as a relationship between three categories of control: between the metropolitan state, the core areas and the peripheral regions.'[32] Her definition is based on the history of the political formation, the nature of the administration, and the character of the economy. The metropolitan state was Magadha, a state with centralized bureaucratic control much before the Mauryas. The core areas were already states before they were conquered by the Mauryas, states like Gandhara and Avanti. On the other hand, the peripheral regions were areas of relative isolation with no antecedent histories of state formation, but possessing natural resources much valued